

Ms Karen Westwood

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By hand and by email to k.westwood@granthorne.co.uk · Strictly Private & Confidential

Dear Karen,

FORMAL GRIEVANCE: bullying behaviour and unequal treatment by my line manager

I am writing to lodge a formal grievance under the Company's Grievance Procedure (Section 9 of the Employee Handbook). I confirm that I would like this to be dealt with under the formal procedure rather than informally.

The substance of my grievance has two strands, both relating to the conduct and decisions of my line manager, Mr Daniel Morley, Head of Operations:

1. Bullying and undermining behaviour

Over the past 14 months Mr Morley has, in my respectful view, engaged in a course of conduct which has been humiliating, undermining and detrimental to my wellbeing and my ability to do my job. The specific examples I rely on are set out below. All dates are taken from my contemporaneous notebook, which I will make available to the investigator, and can be cross-referenced against meeting invites, Teams chats and emails in the Granthorne systems.

(a) Public humiliation in the 12 December 2024 Leadership meeting. In the weekly Operations Leadership meeting on 12 December 2024 (10:00 to 11:30, Trafford Boardroom), I presented the South network winter contingency plan. Mr Morley interrupted me twice, then said, in the presence of the seven other attendees (Sarah Brentwood, Tomasz Bednarski, Priya Mehta, Ross Hopkin, Daniel Aitchison, Mike Kershaw and Sam Heaney): "Honestly, Leah, this is frankly amateur. I expected better." I asked him after the meeting whether we could discuss the feedback privately. He responded, in front of Priya Mehta: "No, you needed to hear that in the room. That's the point." The same contingency plan was subsequently adopted, substantively unchanged, for the 2024/25 peak period and delivered a 96.1% SLA against a 92% target.

(b) Shouting incident on 4 March 2025. I had circulated a peak-recovery plan on the morning of 4 March 2025 in response to the snow disruption at the Daventry hub. Mr Morley called me into his office at 15:40. He shouted at me, banged his hand on the desk twice, and said: "You do not put plans like this

out under my name without my sign-off. Ever. Do you understand me?” I left the meeting visibly upset. Priya Mehta and Tomasz Bednarski were in the open-plan area immediately outside the office and both asked me afterwards whether I was alright. I went home shortly afterwards and was off work the following day. I have a doctor’s note for the absence.

(c) Pattern of exclusion from decisions about the South network. Throughout 2025, Mr Morley repeatedly took decisions affecting the South network (for which I am directly accountable) without consulting me, and informed me only after the fact. I have logged at least nine such instances. The clearest examples are:

- On 11 February 2025, Mr Morley signed off a route consolidation at Avonmouth (removing two trunk routes from the night plan) without informing me. I learned of the change from Mike Kershaw on the morning of 13 February, after the change had taken effect and after two customer complaints had been received.
- On 8 May 2025, Mr Morley directly briefed Sam Heaney (Senior Operations Manager, North) on a Q2 reforecast for the South region, while excluding me from the call. I was told about this by Sam Heaney in passing on 12 May 2025.
- On 17 September 2025, Mr Morley agreed a SLA waiver with Halterley Foods (one of my retained customers) for the week commencing 22 September without consulting me. I only became aware when Halterley’s commercial director, Ben Auerbach, asked me about it in our standing call on 24 September.

(d) Repeated questioning of my competence in front of more junior staff. Mr Morley has, on at least four documented occasions in 2025, questioned my competence in front of staff more junior than me. The dates and brief context are:

- **17 April 2025** (South Hub walkround, Daventry): in front of three shift managers, Mr Morley said: “You’d think after this long Leah would have a handle on a yard plan, but here we are.”
- **2 June 2025** (Operations Leadership stand-up, Trafford): in front of seven attendees including two of my direct reports (Priya Mehta and Daniel Aitchison), Mr Morley said: “I’m not sure Leah has the strategic chops for what’s coming. We’ll see.”
- **13 August 2025** (Reading driver brief): in front of approximately twelve drivers and the site manager, Mr Morley contradicted a fatigue-management instruction I had given the day before, saying: “Ignore what Leah said. I make the rota calls on this site.”
- **22 October 2025** (Q3 customer review with Sandalwood Foods, attended by Ross Hopkin and the customer’s account team): Mr Morley said, when the customer raised a missed-window complaint: “That’s on Leah, not on us as a business. We’ll have a word.” The missed window was, as the post-incident review subsequently confirmed, caused by a depot system outage, not by anything within my control.

(e) Impact on my wellbeing. The cumulative effect of the conduct above has been significant. I have been signed off by my GP for two short periods (5 March 2025 and 24 to 28 March 2025) with work-

related stress and have been prescribed sertraline since June 2025. My fit notes are with HR. I have also referred myself to the Health Assured employee assistance programme; the reference number is HA-25-118332.

I consider that this conduct, taken as a whole and viewed objectively, is inconsistent with the Company's Dignity at Work policy and amounts to a sustained course of bullying behaviour within the meaning of that policy.

2. Repeated denial of promotion in favour of less experienced male colleagues

I have applied for two internal promotions during my time with the Company. On both occasions the role was awarded to a male colleague who had materially less relevant experience than I did:

- **Senior Operations Manager (February 2024):** the role went to Mr Sam Heaney, who at the time had approximately three years of operations experience, compared with my then-twelve years. Mr Morley sat on the interview panel.
- **Head of Strategic Operations (November 2025):** the role went to Mr Ross Hopkin, who had at that time been employed by the Company for only seven months and had no prior network-management experience. Mr Morley was the recruiting manager.

I have no feedback on either decision beyond a brief verbal comment from Mr Morley on the second occasion that my profile was "more operational than strategic". I would respectfully suggest that the comparators' profiles do not bear that distinction out.

I am concerned that the pattern of decisions is not consistent with the Company's stated commitment to fair recruitment and progression, and that the decisions, taken with the conduct described in section 1 above, may evidence direct or indirect sex discrimination contrary to sections 13 and 19 of the Equality Act 2010.

3. What I am asking for

I would be grateful if this grievance could be investigated promptly under the formal procedure. I am happy to provide further detail, dates, supporting documents and the names of witnesses to whoever is appointed as the investigator.

For obvious reasons I would ask that the investigator is not someone within Mr Morley's direct line of report, and that Mr Morley is not provided with my notebook or witness details until and unless required for the purposes of the formal investigation.

If practicable, I would also welcome interim adjustments to my reporting line (for example, reporting on a temporary basis to the Chief Operating Officer) while the matter is investigated.

I appreciate this is a difficult letter to receive and I want to be constructive in resolving it. I look forward to hearing from you within the timescales set out in the Grievance Procedure.

Yours sincerely,

L Miller

Leah Miller

Operations Manager, Network South · Employee No. GR-0431

cc: Mr Anthony Granthorne, Chief Executive (by sealed envelope, marked private)

Enc: none with this letter; further documents will be provided to the investigator on appointment.